

Synesius Stanislao Ilovio Polono interprete.

A newly acquired 16th century book in the collection of the National Library of Poland

In 2006 the National Library of Poland purchased for its collection of early printed books¹ a copy of a Latin edition of *Peri basileias*², an oration by Synesius of Cyrene (A.D. ca. 370 – ca. 413)³ addressed to Emperor Arcadius, published in 1563 in Venice⁴ (fig. 1). The oration, delivered by Synesius before the imperial court in Constantinople in 399,⁵ gave the philosopher a chance

to present a neo-Platonic survey of a ruler's virtues and duties, following the rich tradition of ancient *parainesis*⁶. The translation discussed in this paper, one of the earliest printed Latin adaptations of Synesius' speech⁷, was penned by Stanisław Iłowski (d. 1589), a Polish scholar in the Humanities⁸.

Stanisław Iłowski was the son of Aleksander, governor of the district of Płock. Having graduated from Cracow University, in 1555 Iłowski took to studying Rhetoric in Basel under Celio Secondo Curione⁹, who influenced him to begin translating Greek authors. In the following year in Paris he met a renowned French humanist Robert Etienne and published a translation of writings

¹ Call no. BN XVI.Qu.7390; cf. Antykwariat "Rara avis" Z. Migo-Rożek & J. Pawlak, 69 aukcja antykwaryczna. Awangarda – sztuka – wydawnictwa XIX – XXI w. – księgozbiór Romana Żurowskiego, 21 października 2006 (Warszawa 2006) 80, no. 602.

² *Synesii Cyrenensis hymni et opuscula*, ed. N. Terzaghi, II (Rome 1944) 5-62.

³ A. Di Berardino (ed.), *Nuovo dizionario patristico e di antichità cristiane* (Genova – Milano 2008) s. v. Sinesio di Cirene (E. Cavalcanti). The writings of the bishop of Ptolemais (in A.D. 411 – 413) are essential in the studies of ancient historians and archaeologists, as they constitute a valuable source of information on the domestic affairs in Cyrenaica and provide a reference point for conclusions based on archaeological research: D. Roques, *Synésios de Cyrène et la Cyrénaïque du Bas-Empire* (Paris 1987); cf. commentaries thereof in: *Synésios de Cyrène, Correspondance*, ed. A. Garzya, I-II (Paris 2000); J.B. Ward-Perkins – R.G. Goodchild, *Christian monuments of Cyrenaica*, ed. J. Reynolds (London 2003) *passim*; R.G. Goodchild, *Synesius of Cyrene. Bishop of Ptolemais*, in: *Libyan studies. Selected papers of the late R.G. Goodchild* (London 1976) 239-253.

⁴ *Synesii episcopi Cyrenes Ad Arcadium imperatorem liber de regno bene administrando Stanislao Ilovio Polono interprete, ad amplissimum regni Poloniae procancellarium Petrum Miscovium, Venetiis, apud Io. Baptistam Somaschum (post 13 II) 1563* (= Estr. 30, p. 123); cf. J. Czerniatowicz – C. Mazur, *Recepcja antyku chrześcijańskiego w Polsce. Materiały bibliograficzne I*, 1 (Lublin 1978) 76, no. 481.

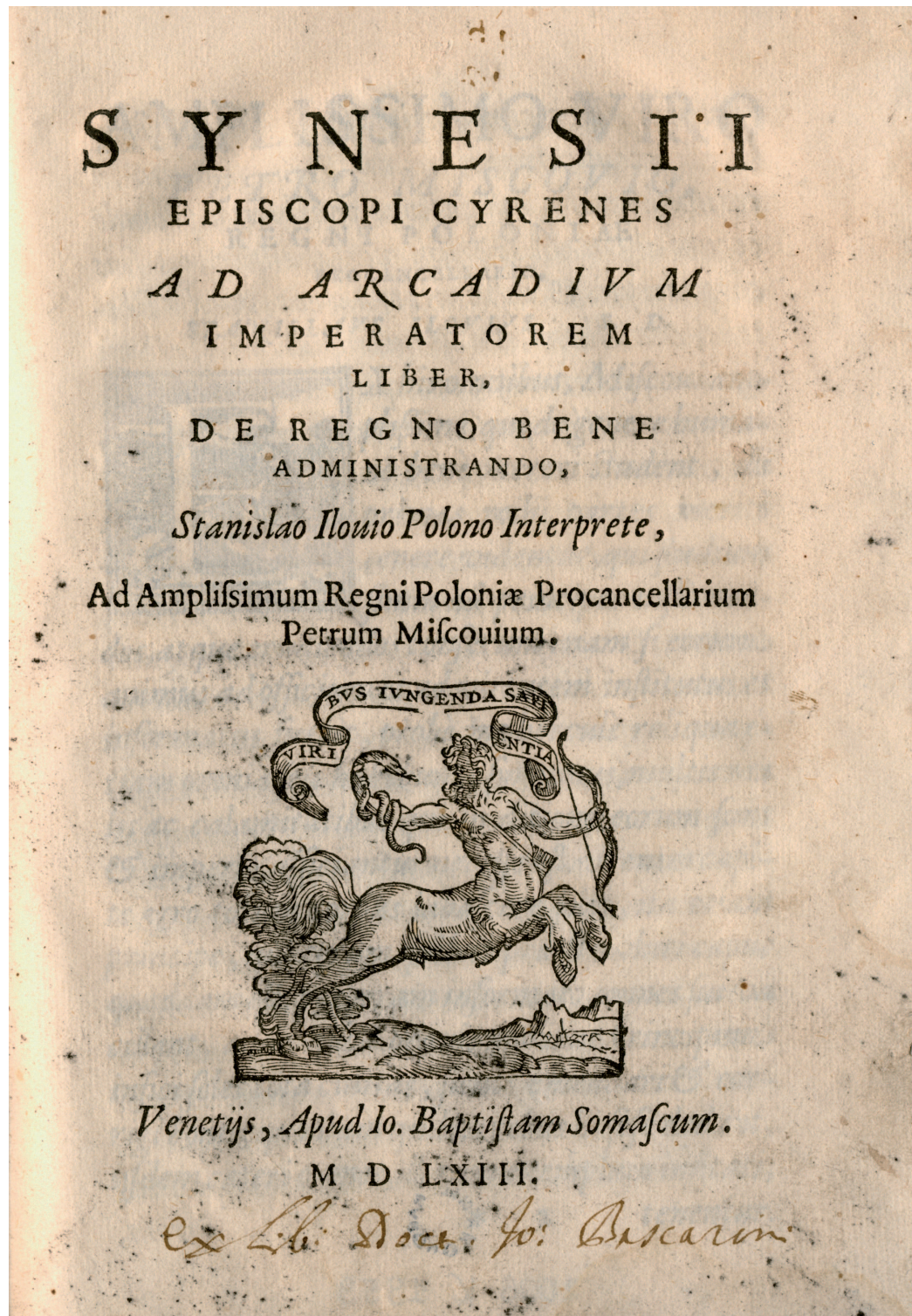
⁵ A. Cameron – J. Long, *Barbarians and politics at the Court of Arcadius, The Transformation of the classical heritage*, 19 (Berkeley–Los Angeles–Oxford 1993) 103-142.

⁶ On the oration of Synesius addressed to Arcadius and its European reception compared to other works of ancient political *parainesis* see A. Kempfi, *O Synezjuszu z Kyreny i jego "Zwierciadło królewskie"*, *Meander* 17, 6, 1962, 307-317. A. Kempfi brought attention to Iłowski's humanist translation; he is also the author of the first Polish translation of Synesius' speech: *Synesios z Kyreny, Mowa do cesarza Arkadiusza czyli zwierciadło doskonałego króla*, tr. A. Kempfi, *Meander* 17, 9, 1962, 441-454 and 17, 10, 1962, 487-502.

⁷ An earlier translation: *Synesii Cyrenaei oratio ad Arcadium Theodosii f. de regno, id est, de officio imperatoris seu regis. Continent praeepta salutaria rebus communibus et privatis. Conversa in Latinum sermonem. Addita historiola de autore. A Ioachimo Camerario Pabeperg, Lipsiae, in officina Valentini Papae 1555* (= VD 16 S 10424; Estr. 30, p. 123 – the work contains a dedication to Jan Bonar).

⁸ PSB X (1962/1963) 160-161, s. v. Iłowski Stanisław (J. Czerniatowicz – B. Nadolski).

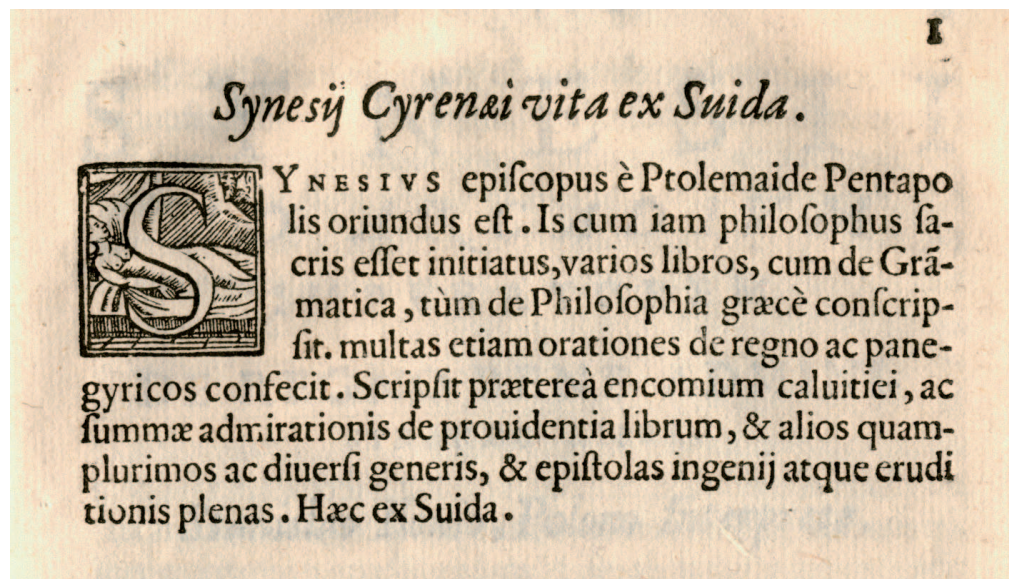
⁹ M. Włodarski, *Dwa wieki kulturalnych i literackich powiązań polsko-bazyjskich 1433-1632* (Kraków 2001) 88.

■ *fig. 1*

Title page of Synesius' *Ad Arcadium imperatorem liber de regno bene administrando*, translated by Stanislaw Ilowski, Venice 1563 (photo National Library of Poland, call no. XVI. Qu.7390)

■ *fig. 2*

Life of Synesius according to the Suda, fragment of the recto of leaf A1 (photo National Library of Poland, call no. XVI.Qu.7390)



by Dionysius of Halicarnassus¹⁰. In 1557 he re-published Dionysius' works along with a translation of *Peri herme-neias* by Demetrius of Phaleron¹¹. Iłowski's co-edition of *De historica facultate* published in the same volume is considered the first Polish essay in historical methodology¹². In 1563 Iłowski travelled to Padova to study under Francesco Robortello. The then-published translation of Synesius' *Peri basileias* opened with Iłowski's dedication to Piotr Myszkowski (ca. 1510-1591), Deputy Chancellor of the Crown¹³, later bishop of Płock and subsequently of Cracow, whose patronage the scholar was seeking. Myszkowski, an alumnus of universities in Cracow and Padova, was himself an important representative of Polish Humanism, and after assuming high office he became a praiseworthy patron of writers and

scholars¹⁴. Among his protégés was Jan Kochanowski, whom Myszkowski introduced to the Royal Chancellery at the turn of 1563/1564¹⁵. Myszkowski was particularly favoured by King Sigismund Augustus, from whom he received many land grants and was promoted to the office of Deputy Chancellor, also in 1563. As a result, he became an important agent of royal political affairs¹⁶. Myszkowski's good relations with the king made him an ideal addressee of the dedication in the edition of Synesius' speech to the emperor on the duties of a good ruler¹⁷. Iłowski's efforts were not in vain. In 1569, three years after the scholar's return to Poland, Myszkowski (who had been nominated Bishop of Płock by papal bull) appointed him to the office of canon theologian in this city, which he held until his death († 1673)¹⁸.

¹⁰ *Dionysii Halicarnassei nonnulla opuscula, a Stanislao Ilovio nunc primum latinate donata. Eiusdem Ilovii et Robortelli de historica facultate commentatiunculae*, Lutetiae, ex officina Roberti Stephani 1556 (= IA 154.241; Estr. 15, p. 211).

¹¹ *De elocutione liber, a Stanislao Ilovio Polono Latinitate donatus et annotationibus illustratus. Item Dionysii Halicarnassei quaedam opuscula, eodem interprete...*, Basileae, per Io. Oporinum 1557 (= IA 151.181, VD 16 D 472; Adams D-252; Estr. 15, p. 134; Wierzb. 166); cf. L. Winniczuk, Demetriusza z Faleronu *De elocutione* w przekładach łacińskich Franciszka Masłowskiego i Stanisława Iłowskiego, *Eos* 45, 2, 1951, 13-24.

¹² G. Korbut, *Literatura polska od początków do wojny światowej*, I² (Warszawa 1929) 176-177.

¹³ PSB XXII (1977) 382-390, s. v. Myszkowski Piotr (L. Ajdukiewicz – H. Kowalska).

¹⁴ Ł. Kurdybacha, *Działalność kulturalna Piotra Myszkowskiego biskupa krakowskiego*, (Lwów 1935).

¹⁵ PSB XXII (1977) 386, s. v. Myszkowski Piotr (L. Ajdukiewicz – H. Kowalska).

¹⁶ *Ibidem*, 383.

¹⁷ The collection of Zygmunt August included a Greek edition of Synesius' *Peri basileias*, published in Paris in 1553 (= Adams S-2206); cf. A. Kawecka-Gryczowa, *Biblioteka ostatniego Jagiellona. Pomnik kultury renesansowej* (Wrocław 1988) 222, no. 581.

¹⁸ PSB X (1962/1963) 161, s. v. Iłowski Stanisław (J. Czerniatowicz – B. Nadolski).

Howski's Latin translation of Synesius' oration was released by the publishing house of Giovanni Battista Somasco (fl. 1562-1599)¹⁹. The book is *in quarto* format. On the title page and on the *verso* of the last leaf is a printer's mark which features a running Centaur with a snake and a bow in his hands and a proverb: VIRIBVS IVNGENDA SAPIENTIA. The edition is characterised by an elegant typographical layout and stylish design of its Renaissance antiqua typeface, typical for Venetian printing. Especially noteworthy are decorative figural initials in "all'antica" style. The work includes four unnumbered leaves (containing the dedication to Piotr Myszkowski) and 20 leaves of the proper text preceded by short biographical notes on Synesius based on the Suda and on Evagrius (fig. 2). There are several copies of this edition in Polish libraries²⁰. Also noteworthy in the collections of the National Library of Poland is

a 15th-century Greek manuscript from the Zamoyski Estate Library (Biblioteka Ordynacji Zamojskiej), containing – besides texts of several ancient authors – also *Catastases* and *Homiliae* by Synesius²¹.

The copy of the Venetian edition of *Peri basileias* in the collection of the National Library of Poland is in a good state of preservation. It has a secondary cardboard binding and marks of provenance²², among which especially remarkable is a note of ownership at the bottom of the title page ("ex lib. Doct. Jo: Bascarini"), most probably attributable to the well-known Florentine astronomer, poet and physician Giovanni Bascarini²³.

INSTITUTE OF ARCHAEOLOGY

UNIVERSITY OF WARSAW

studium.rei.nummariae@gmail.com

Abbreviations

- | | |
|---|--|
| <p>Adams H.M. Adams (ed.), <i>Catalogue of books printed on the continent of Europe, 1501-1600 in Cambridge libraries</i>, I-II (Cambridge 1967)</p> <p>BJ 16 M. Malicki (ed.), <i>Catalogus librorum saeculi XVI qui in Bibliotheca Jagellonica Cracoviensis asservantur</i>, I-VIII, <i>Bibliotheca bibliographica Aureliana</i> 192 (Baden-Baden 2002-2005)</p> <p>Estr. K. Estreicher – S. Estreicher, <i>Bibliografia polska. Stulecie XV-XVIII, XII-XXXV</i> (Kraków 1891-2007)</p> | <p>IA <i>Index Aureliensis. Catalogus librorum sedecimo saeculo impressorum</i>, I-XII (Aureliae Aquensis [Baden-Baden] 1965-2000)</p> <p>PSB Polski Słownik Biograficzny (Wrocław)</p> <p>VD 16 I. Bezzel (ed.), <i>Verzeichnis der im deutschen sprachbereich erschienenen Drucke des XVI. Jahrhunderts</i>, I-XXV (Stuttgart 1983-2000)</p> <p>Wierzb. T. Wierzbowski, <i>Polonica XV ac XVI ss. sive catalogus librorum res Polonicas tractantium vel a polonis conscriptorum arte typographica impressorum, qui in bibliotheca Universitatis Caesariae Varsoviensis asservantur...</i>, I-III (Varsoviae 1889-1894)</p> |
|---|--|

¹⁹ G. Borsa, *Clavis typographorum librariorumque Italiae 1465-1600*, I, *Bibliotheca bibliographica Aureliana* 85 (Aureliae Aquensis [Baden-Baden] 1980) 302.

²⁰ Copies in the following collections: University of Warsaw Library (Wierzb. 243); Jagiellonian Library (BJ 16 S-1472); Library of the Polish Academy of Sciences in Cracow (call no. 2024 St. dr.); Ossolineum (M. Bohonos, *Katalog starych druków Biblioteki Zakładu Narodowego im. Ossolińskich. Polonica wieku XVI* (Wrocław 1965) 681, no. 2482); The Kórnik Library (K. Piekarski, *Katalog Biblioteki Kórnickiej*, I. *Polonica XVI-go wieku* (Kórnik 1929) 200, no. 1458); see also J. Trypućko, *Polonica vetera Upsaliensia*. *Catalogue des imprimés polonais ou concernant la Pologne des XVe, XVIe, XVIIe et XVIIIe siècles conservés à la Bibliothèque de l'Université Royale d'Upsala*, *Acta Bibliothecae R. Universitatis Upsaliensis* 13 (Uppsala 1958) 162.

²¹ Call no. BOZ 125: B. Kocówna – K. Muszyńska (ed.), *Inventory of manuscripts at the Zamoyski Estate Library*, call no. 1-2051 (Warszawa 1967) 12.

²² Pasted on the front endpaper is a cut out coat-of-arms (unidentified); on the back endpaper – the call number of the collection (A.IV.47).

²³ P. Larousse, *Grand dictionnaire universel du XIXe siècle...*, II (Paris 1867) 297; *Indice Biografico Italiano I* (München 2000) 314.